PRETERITE VS IMPERFECT: PART IV

Notes:

1. The written lesson is below.
2. Links to quizzes, tests, etc. are to the left.

Here are all three regular preterite verb forms together:

hablar	comer	vivir
hablé	comí	viví
hablaste	comiste	viviste
habló	comió	vivió
hablamos	comimos	vivimos
hablasteis	comisteis	vivisteis
hablaron	comieron	vivieron

Note: The nosotros forms for -ar and -ir verbs are the same in both preterite and present tenses: **hablamos, vivimos**.

[Review This Topic]

Here are all three regular imperfect verb forms together:

Privacy

hablar	comer	vivir
hablaba	comía	vivía
hablabas	comías	vivías
hablaba	comía	vivía
hablábamos	comíamos	vivíamos
hablabais	comíais	vivíais
hablaban	comían	vivían

[Review This Topic]

Generally speaking, the preterite is used for actions in the past that are seen as completed, while the imperfect tense is used for past actions that did not have a definite beginning or a definite end.

Juan habló dos horas.
Juan spoke two hours.
(action completed)

Las chicas hablaban en inglés.
The girls used to speak in English.
(no definite beginning or end)

Another way to view this is that the preterite tells us **specifically** when an action took place, while the imperfect tells us **in general** when an action took place.

[Review This Topic]

The preterite is used in the following situations:

Privacy

- *For actions that can be viewed as single events*
- *For actions that were repeated a specific number of times*
- *For actions that occurred during a specific period of time*
- *For actions that were part of a chain of events*
- *To state the beginning or the end of an action*

[Review This Topic]

The imperfect is used in the following situations:

- *For actions that were repeated habitually*
- *For actions that "set the stage" for another past action*
- *For telling time*
- *For stating one's age*
- *For mental states (usually)*
- *For physical sensations (usually)*
- *To describe the characteristics of people, things or conditions*

[Review This Topic]

Ser, ir, dar and hacer are irregular in the preterite:

ser	ir	dar	hacer
fui	fui	di	hice
fuiste	fuiste	diste	hiciste
fue	fue	dio	hizo
fuimos	fuimos	dimos	hicimos
fuisteis	fuisteis	disteis	hicisteis
fueron	fueron	dieron	hicieron

Note: This is not a typo; ser and ir do have identical conjugations in the preterite!

Privacy

[Review This Topic]

There are only three irregular verbs in the imperfect:

ser	ir	ver
era	iba	veía
eras	ibas	veías
era	iba	veía
éramos	íbamos	veíamos
erais	ibais	veíais
eran	iban	veían

[Review This Topic]

Some words and phrases indicate specific time frames, and therefore signal the use of the preterite.

Privacy

ayer *(yesterday)*
anteayer *(the day before yesterday)*
anoche *(last night)*
desde el primer momento *(from the first moment)*
durante dos siglos *(for two centuries)*
el otro día *(the other day)*
en ese momento *(at that moment)*
entonces *(then)*
esta mañana *(this morning)*
esta tarde *(this afternoon)*
la semana pasada *(last week)*
el mes pasado *(last month)*
el año pasado *(last year)*
hace dos días, años *(two days, years ago)*
ayer por la mañana *(yesterday morning)*
ayer por la tarde *(yesterday afternoon)*

[Review This Topic]

Other words and phrases indicate repetitive, vague or non-specific time frames, and therefore signal the use of the imperfect.

Privacy

a menudo *(often)*
a veces *(sometimes)*
cada día *(every day)*
cada semana *(every week)*
cada mes *(every month)*
cada año *(every year)*
con frecuencia *(frequently)*
de vez en cuando *(from time to time)*
en aquella época *(at that time)*
frecuentemente *(frequently)*
generalmente *(usually)*
muchas veces *(many times)*
mucho *(a lot)*
nunca *(never)*
por un rato *(for awhile)*
siempre *(always)*
tantas veces *(so many times)*
todas las semanas *(every week)*
todos los días *(every day)*
todo el tiempo *(all the time)*
varias veces *(several times)*

[Review This Topic]

-ar and -er verbs that change their stem in the present tense **do not** change in the preterite. They are conjugated just like other regular preterite verbs.

Present	Preterite
cerrar	**cerrar**
c**ie**rro	cerré
c**ie**rras	cerraste
c**ie**rra	cerró

Privacy

cerramos	cerramos
cerráis	cerrasteis
c**ie**rran	cerraron

[Review This Topic]

-ir verbs that change their stem in the present tense **do** change in the preterite, but in a different way. They change e:i and o:u in the third person, singular and plural.

Present	**Preterite**
preferir	**preferir**
pref**ie**ro	preferí
pref**ie**res	preferiste
pref**ie**re	pref**i**rió
preferimos	preferimos
preferís	preferisteis
pref**ie**ren	pref**i**rieron

Present	**Preterite**
dormir	**dormir**
d**ue**rmo	dormí
d**ue**rmes	dormiste

Privacy

d**ue**rme	d**u**rmió
dormimos	dormimos
dormís	dormisteis
d**ue**rmen	d**u**rmieron

[Review This Topic]

There are a number of orthographic changing verbs in the preterite:

- *Verbs that end in -gar change g to gu*
- *Verbs that end in -car change c to qu*
- *Verbs that end in -zar change z to c*
- *Verbs that end in -aer, -eer, -oír, -oer, and uir change ió to yó and ieron to yeron*

[Review This Topic]

Here are three more verbs that are irregular in the preterite:

decir	**traer**	**ver**
dije	traje	vi
dijiste	trajiste	viste
dijo	trajo	vio
dijimos	trajimos	vimos
dijisteis	trajisteis	visteis
dijeron	trajeron	vieron

[Review This Topic]

Privacy

Verbs that end in **-ucir** are irregular and conjugated as follows:

producir

*produ**je***
*produ**jiste***
*produ**jo***
*produ**jimos***
*produ**jisteis***
*produ**jeron***

[Review This Topic]

There are a number of verbs that are irregular in the preterite that follow a particular pattern. The pattern is that while their stems change, they all take the following endings:

-e
-iste
-o
-imos
-isteis
-ieron

Here are the verbs, along with their corresponding stem changes:

Infinitive	Stem Change
andar	anduv-
estar	estuv-
tener	tuv-
caber	cup-

Privacy

haber	hub-
poder	pud-
poner	pus-
saber	sup-
hacer	hic-
querer	quis-
venir	vin-

Exception: hacer (el/ella/usted hizo)

[Review This Topic]

Some verbs actually change meaning, depending upon whether they are used in the preterite or the imperfect. This is not surprising, since the difference in meaning can be traced back to the different way in which these two past tenses are used.

conocer

__Conocí__ a Juan hace cinco años.

I __met__ Juan five years ago.
(completed action)

En aquella época __conocíamos__ muy bien la ciudad.

At that time we __knew__ the city very well.
(no definite beginning or end)

querer

Privacy

*María **quiso** comprar la casa.*

*Maria **tried** to buy the house.*
(completed action)

*Juan **quería** comprar la casa.*

*Juan **wanted** to buy the house.*
(no definite beginning or end)

no querer

*María **no quiso** comprar la casa.*

*Maria **refused** to buy the house.*
(completed action)

*Juan **no quería** comprar la casa.*

*Juan **did not want** to buy the house.*
(no definite beginning or end)

saber

*María lo **supo** ayer.*

*Maria **found out** yesterday.*
(completed action)

*Juan **sabía** que María venía.*

*Juan **knew** that Maria was coming.*
(no definite beginning or end)

poder

Privacy

*María **pudo** levantar la mesa.*

*Maria **succeeded in** lifting the table.*
(completed action)

*Juan **podía** participar en la manifestación.*

*Juan **was able** to participate in the demonstration.*
(no definite beginning or end)

tener

*María **tuvo** una carta de su mamá.*

*Maria **received** a letter from her mom.*
(completed action)

*Juan **tenía** un coche nuevo.*

*Juan **used to have** a new car.*
(no definite beginning or end)

[Review This Topic]

Privacy

© 1997–2021 Study Languages, LLC. All Rights Reserved.

Privacy